THE NORMANDY LANDINGS

The invasion of Normandy by Allied forces on June 6, 1944, was the largest amphibious operation in military history. The naval aspect of the landings was known as Operation Neptune. The naval forces had three major functions: to transport troops and equipment across the English Channel; to protect the invasion force against attack by German surface warships or submarines; and to bombard the German land defenses. That the operation succeeded should not hide the fact that it involved considerable risks.

From a naval point of view, bad weather was probably the most serious hazard, for heavy seas would have prevented the landings entirely. Weather did in fact force a postponement from the original planned D-Day of June 5, and conditions on June 6 were far from perfect. This resulted in most troops arriving at the beaches seasick, but put the German defenders off their guard, since they considered an invasion in such weather unlikely.



Midget submarine helmet
The first craft off the shore of Normandy on D-Day were midget submarines that guided the invasion force toward the beaches with navigation beacons.

Intervention by German naval forces also had to be taken seriously. During a rehearsal for D-Day at Slapton Sands in southern England in April 1944, a group of German Fast Attack Boats (E-boats) struck a convoy of landing craft and killed more than 600 American servicemen. If E-boats, U-boats, or even large surface warships had got among the landing craft during the actual landings the death toll could have been serious. In the event, the threat of the German navy was nullified. Air patrols kept U-boats out of the English Channel, while minefields and screening destroyers blocked the possibility of surface attacks.

The massive invasion fleet put to sea on the night of June 5-6, the American Western Task Force under Rear Admiral Alan G. Kirk and the British and Canadian Eastern Task Force under Rear Admiral Sir Philip Vian. The convoys formed up south of the Isle of Wight and crossed the English Channel through "the Spout," a series of lanes swept clear of mines. Midget submarines laid navigation beacons approaching the Normandy coast. The naval bombardment of the coastal defenses behind the five landing beaches was formidable. Kirk's force consisted of three battleships—*Nevada*, *Texas,* and *Arkansas*—nine cruisers, and 20 destroyers. Vian had the battleships *Warspite* and *Ramillies*, along with 12 cruisers and 37 destroyers.

The operation did not end with the landings. Naval forces had to maintain the supply lifeline across the English Channel, using the famous Mulberry artificial harbors towed across to Normandy. Naval guns continued to bombard German land forces as the fighting moved inland. There were losses to mines and air attacks, duels with coastal artillery, and occasional fights with German destroyers. But taken as a whole the Normandy invasion was a remarkable demonstration of the command of the sea and the importance of logistics.

Normandy beachhead
Fleets of US transport and landing craft disgorge their cargoes onto the beaches at Normandy. Barrage balloons overhead protect against German strafing aircraft.

WORLD WAR II



THE NORMANDY LANDINGS

Date	June 6–30, 1944
Location	Normandy, northern France
Result	Allied victory

COMBATANTS

ALLIES	GERMANY

COMMANDERS

Sir Bertram Ramsay	Gerd von Rundstedt Erwin Rommel

FORCES

Ships: 1,213 warships (including 6 battleships and 25 cruisers), 4,126 landing craft, 1,600 support vessels	**Ships:** unknown

LOSSES

Ships: 59	**Ships:** unknown



D-Day landing craft
A British Landing Craft Assault (LCA) ferries US troops to shore during the rehearsals for the Normandy landings.

